

“PROLOGUE”

It was one of the most beautiful days for the people of Walyord. This day has been celebrated for centuries, and have its own story. Of course, as always the meaning of the day was forgotten. Reality and the history were replaced by some children's bedtime stoires- of course they only told the lovely parts or the parts that changed in time- or they turned into legends in ballad of bards. With time, mankind started to ignore and forget the past, and the suffer they had been through. Still they were there, celebrating the event they do not believe it had happened. All would join in the celebration of a foreigner who had saved the drought-stricken kingdom, the greatest victory for them. It was a day of fun and joy. Even tho most of them didn't believe it had happened, still, they were there, willing to participate.

One of the latest day of summer, S'vano- the festival was called- also brought the cold wind of the fall. Not making the people freeze but cooling them down. Street of the Walyord Kingdom were covered with the slience of death because all of the people were already gathered the open area near the forest. Lots of campfire were set under the inadequate light of the stars and the moon. Bards were spread all over the camp side, of course they were sitting as far as they could from each other for protecting their song from mingling with others, some were playing his lute and sing his own song alone and some were singing in minstrels. They all were playing different kind of show.

Adults, young ones and childen were sitting spreaded to three different area. Some of the adults were already got drunk by their cheap beer while the others were chatting accompanied by the bard's songs. Children were nearest to the forest. They were running all over the places, playing games. And young ones, Some of the boys were asking to the girls to dance with the songs, others were sitting around fires with a group of friend for chatting.

In sudden, all the eyes saw the same elderly man. Repar. An old man who always have a story to tell that no one ever heard of it. With his smiling face and kindness he was loved by everyone eventhough no one knew where he was from. He was in Walyord in every S'vano, telling to stories to the ones who willing to listen.

Repar saluted with his big smile to everyone he had seen. He walked through the adult groups, limpingly. And of course he passed by other elders who looked like about his age. Limped through the youngs who were dancing and he sat near a camp fire that he had his

eye on. In a short time a lot of young ones were already gathered near the same campfire. Some just got up from the place they were sat to listen Repar's stories, Some girls just grabbed the wrist of the boys they were dancing to bring them to listen the stories together. All of them got their sit.

As always Repar looked at them with his lovely smile.

"Henry, tell me what is new? I didn't see you for a year. Ashley, how is your old man? What about you Xander? How the life going on?"

While Repar were having conversations with the youngs he knew for a long time, there were more people gathered around his campfire. And finally a girl from the back asked the question most of the youngs had in their mind.

"Mr. Repar, Which tale you gonna tell us today?"

"Good question Charlie." Said Repar and thought a moment with frowning eyebrows, watching the dance of fire. "I believe it is the time for a long story. But this time I won't change or hiding the bothering truths. It will be different from the stories that were told for making children sleep but I am sure you gonna like it." He looked around himself. Searching for something. And his eyes finally caught a similiar face. A bard with a violin. He made a sign with his hand and the bard without stopping come to the campfire. The embroiders on his shirt were more noticable when he got closer. Both side of the shirt had a shape just looks like the two hole in violin, of course on shirt it was filled with other details.

"Sebastian, would you be kind and bring a big cup of a beer, one of the good ones. And after that as you know I need bard that can sing songs based on my stories and its changes."

"Of course, Mr. Repar. You didn't even needed to ask." Said Sebastian, left his violin next to repar and went to the tables filled with every kind of drink and lots of delicious food.

"We can start now and the bard can join us later.

"The story that I am gonna tell you is a history of a land far far from here. Don't think anyone in this world heard of it. You will hear the nemes you have never heard, and you also hear the names that you already heard in other stories but I ensure you that none of you had heard the story I am gonna tell you." With the dancing fire the words found their own place in Repars mind. With a satisfied smile he started.

"Near the caves of crossroads, there was a kingdom. And the history starts in that kingdom. Kingdom of Mandrethia."

CHAPTER I

“RANDAL”

The streets of the city called Mandrethia—the heart and the first land of the kingdom, which is why it bore the same name—were much more lively than on other days. Most of the people were moving in the same direction. Stores, restaurants, banks... everyone had taken a break from their work, closing up their places to make it to the arena in time. And while most of the crowd was still moving toward the arena, the first horn was heard all over the city.

The sound of the horn was a sign that the tournament was close. The first of the three horns. It was telling the contestants to get ready.

Malvrick Vern Mattson, the king’s nephew, was sitting inside one of the tents lined up right next to the arena. As he looked at himself in the mirror standing right in front of him, he let out one last deep breath. He was trying to control his excitement. With the sound of the first horn, Edgar entered. Edgar was a skinny, young slave who came up to Vern’s shoulder, though Vern never treated him as such.

“The first horn has sounded! We should start getting ready, Master Vern.”

“You’re right, Edgar,” Vern said, standing up and turning around. “Tell me, what do you have for me this time?”

Edgar returned his master’s smile as he walked toward the table standing in the back. Spanned over the top of it was a white cloth that only revealed the silhouettes of the items beneath it.

“I didn’t open it before you arrived. I know how much you love showing off the equipment, old friend.”

“Yes, Master Vern,” Edgar said. The moment his hands firmly gripped the cloth, he pulled it off and tossed it aside. The largest piece was the first to catch the eye: the chest piece of the armor. Made entirely of dark leather, the armor had segments extending from the shoulders down to the knees. Engraved on the left side of the chest was Vern’s family crest: a quill suspended in the air inside a shield, with a parchment beneath it.

Of course, the family crest wasn’t the only engraving; besides that, the lines drawn all over the armor and the runic letters between them were eye-catching. The engraved symbols

and decorations were aligned across the other pieces of the armor to harmonize perfectly with the torso. The engravings on the bracers, boots, and belt complemented one another.

“I must admit,” Vern said, running his hand over the carvings on the armor, “Barrett has done a magnificent job, as always.” Continuing his words, he picked up the armor and slid it over his head. Then he raised his arms. Edgar tightened the buckled straps on both sides of the leather armor, fitting it perfectly to Vern’s body. Next, he slid on the bracers, lacing up both of them one by one in a crisscross pattern and tying them in knots. When it came to the boots, Vern handled the task himself. And, of course, his belt as well.

“Are you sure you don’t want to replace your sword with a new one too, Master Vern? Barrett is as much a master of iron as he is of leather. It would only take a single request from you. You could have the finest sword after the king and his dynasty,” Edgar said. Vern gripped the hilt of his sword and drew it slowly, releasing it.

“You know, Edgar, this sword is the only meaningful item left to me by my father,” Vern said, accompanied by the metallic whistle the sword radiated into the surroundings. “The money and the noble blood are all inherited from ancestors, but... but this sword you see is the most valuable among them because it symbolizes the battles he won, the lives he saved, and the justice he provided. For that reason, this sword is his greatest legacy.”

“There's no need for a new sword, but speak with Barrett. Even if I don't need a new sword, the one I have needs to be sturdy. Its hilt is a bit problematic. When I swing it, it feels as if the sword is going to split in two in my hand. And also...” Vern held his sword horizontally to the side, supporting it from the other end with his second hand. He brought it to eye level. “There is a slight bend right here. I would be very pleased if Barrett could repair my sword.” After a momentary silence, he remembered where he was and added, “After the contest, of course.” Then he sheathed the sword.

Placing one hand on the pommel behind his sword, he stepped back in front of the mirror to pose. While trying to ensure everything was ready, checking off the list in his mind, he turned around at the rustling sound coming from the entrance of the tent.

“Well, well, well, a new set of armor. It was necessary anyway! It feels to me like you're getting shorter and shorter,” a voice said from behind Edgar. The leather armor on his torso, featuring purple and golden-yellow engravings, looked as if it were secured with metal pauldrons. With the gold engravings wrapping around the shoulders and the patterns of the leather armor, it looked far, far more flamboyant than Vern’s. Stepping forward, his hand was resting on the hilt of his sword just like Vern’s. Hanging right at his neck was a necklace made of nine interlocking circles, with a symbol inside each circle; the necklace seemed to sway against his chest with his every movement.

After raising an eyebrow and scanning the person who entered the tent for a moment, Vern said with a smile, “Yes, that explains why you change your armor in every contest. What number armor is this for you, eight? Or has it become nine? I’ve lost count by now.” He took a large step toward the man and extended his hand. The man who had just entered the tent took a step toward Vern in the same manner and gripped Vern’s arm. After a momentary handshake, he pulled Vern toward himself.

After hugging Vern tightly, he stepped back. For a brief second, Vern saw the necklace swaying on the armor even more clearly. It was a necklace that did not match his cousin's style.

"We haven't seen each other since the journey. Forgive me, brother. When I arrived, I threw myself straight into bed out of the fatigue of the road. After that, we had a meeting with my father. Damned politics! Believe me, you are very lucky to be the king's nephew and not his son. You don't waste your time with any of these ridiculous endeavors."

"Then today will be a good day. For at least one day, you'll be able to lean back and watch the contests, Esmond."

"Oh no, I am also..." Prince Esmond cut his sentence short at the sight of the mischievous grin on Vern's face. "Your tongue, cousin... your tongue is sharper than your sword."

"Well, your sword is sharper than my tongue, Esmond," Vern said, and at that moment, the second horn was heard. This was the horn calling the contestants to the arena.

Prince Esmond lightly tapped Vern's chest twice with the back of his hand. "They are calling us to the arena. Hurry up and come along. We have contestants to defeat," the Prince said, and slid his helmet over his head. As he turned around, he struck his fist against his chest—right next to his new necklace—with the words, "Good luck, cousin, I hope you last until the end. Knocking you to the ground will be a lot of fun!"

"Good luck to you too, Esmond. I look forward to kicking your ass," Vern said with a grin. The Prince let out a fake laugh as he walked toward the exit of the tent.

"I look forward to seeing you try," he said, and left Vern's tent.

"I suppose we had better take our places as well," Vern said. With a swift movement, Edgar grabbed the shield leaning next to the table and handed it to Vern. After Vern slipped the shield onto his arm and made the final adjustments with the straps, he stepped out of the tent.

The moment he stepped out of the tent, his heart began to beat rapidly. The surroundings were filled with many contestants. Those emerging from the tents were moving toward the arena. They all carried different weapons. They represented the kingdoms they came from through their tents, and their families and lineages through the engravings on their armor. Vern walked through the strangers and headed toward the benches reserved for the contestants. Though he grew more excited with every step, he tried to calm himself by taking deep, deliberate breaths.

When all the contestants arrived before the arena, which resembled a semi-circle, they paid their respects to the king one by one and took their places on the benches on the opposite side of the crescent. While the chatter, bets, and cheers among the common folk drowned the entire arena in a suffocating and unsettling noise, everyone fell into a deathly silence at the sounding of the third horn. The old man sitting in a smaller seat right next to the king stood up. His long, white, braided hair cascading down to his shoulders managed to harmonize with the neatness of his clean-shaven face.

When the man stood up, the crowd became rapt with attention and began to listen to him.

"Citizens of the Marirthan! At the sounding of the third horn, silence your tongues and bend your ears!

"By the grace and command of His Majesty, King Audvin II, we gather here not merely to witness violence or base combat, but to celebrate the enduring strength of our knights and the sacred bonds of our union!

"Brave champions from across the world—from every kingdom and every noble house—stand before you. They have journeyed far with a singular purpose: to represent their lands, their sovereigns, and their kin. Today, they shall prove who among them is worthy of the King's Bounty!

"The rules are simple: A knight may fight until his final breath or his last drop of blood—or he may yield the honor to his opponent by surrendering. While we wish to see this sand washed in the sweat of the brave rather than the blood of the fallen, the choice remains yours! Let the steel speak! Let the trials begin!"

With the commencement of the tournament, the crowd suddenly erupted with enthusiasm. With cheers, applause, and whistles, they supported the contestants advancing toward the center of the semi-circular arena. The majority of the crowd filling the arena supported their prince, Esmond. In the moments when the king caught the sound of his son's name amidst the voices that lost and blended into one another, a small smile, however slight, blossomed on his face.

When Esmond and his opponent drew their swords from their scabbards, the excitement of the crowd intensified further. At the end of the cautious steps they took toward each other, Esmond's sword suddenly rose into the sky. While the people grew even more thrilled with the clashing of the blades and the first sword stroke delivered, all attention suddenly locked onto a stranger who leapt into the arena from among the spectators. Everyone watched the man walking with heavy steps, completely indifferent to what was happening in the arena. The two contestants whose swords had met, the prince and his opponent, took a step back each, trying to understand what was going on.

The stranger was not one of the contestants, nor had he come from the side where the tents were pitched. The dark red cloak he wore billowed backward with his steps, revealing the short sword hanging from his belt.

Vern caught his breath when he saw the symbol engraved on the chest of the armor. His eyes went to Esmond's chest to confirm it. But Esmond had already tucked the necklace inside his collar. Still, Vern had seen that the symbol on the stranger's chest was identical to one of the nine circles on Esmond's necklace.

Vern straightened up and placed his free hand on the pommel of his sword. Even though he felt that something was going wrong, he just waited there.

As the stranger advanced toward the center of the arena, the spectators held their breath, watching with curiosity to see what would happen. The contestants in the arena,

Esmond and his opponent, backed away two steps each. They did not want to drop their guards while trying to understand what the stranger was attempting to do.

"What on earth is this nonsense!" the king finally objected. He shouted, fully displaying the anger stemming from the disruption of his son's match. "Who do you think you are! Don't you see, man, the duel has already begun!" The stranger stopped in his tracks for a moment. "Guards! Remove this fool from the arena!" ordered the king. At that moment, the stranger turned around toward the king.

"I mean no disrespect, you misunderstand me, Your Excellency," the man said. His voice was calm, yet loud enough for the king to hear. It was as if the guards approaching him had no effect at all. The stranger pulled back his hood and offered a bow to the king. When the king raised his hand, the guards advancing toward the stranger halted a few paces away. "I am Randal, I am the new general of the central army of the I'lish empire. And I am here to fulfill my duty. I had no intention of disrupting your tournament. But my master ordered me to bring the necklace that is hanging on your son's neck.

"You should understand that I don't want to make any trouble, but I have to take the necklace or die trying.

"Since we are in the arena, I challenge the Prince. If I win, I will get the necklace and go on my way; if he wins, I will declare my service to him and until the day I die, I will do as your son commands."

"What is it that is so important about that necklace?" the king asked with curiosity.

"I am just following orders, Your Highness."

"I need to speak with my son alone!"

"No need for that, father," said the prince, stepping ahead and taking his helmet off. "Did we not come here to fight, to find the best warrior among the kingdoms? I am Prince Esmond, son of King Audvin the Second, and I accept the challenge."

A smile appeared on the king's face. Standing up, he opened his arms to both sides. "Since my son Esmond has accepted the challenge, this match shall take place! If Esmond wins, Randal will be bound to our kingdom by an oath of loyalty, and immediately afterward, Esmond will begin his second match without rest. Unfortunately, the swords have been drawn and the first blow has been struck. His opponent..."

"Sir Jerome of Ermang," the king's assistant quietly reminded him of the name.

"Right, so as not to show disrespect to his opponent, Sir Jerome, my son will engage directly in his second duel without resting. And if he loses... he will give his necklace to Randal and will be considered eliminated from the tournament."

Esmond struck his balled fist against his chest and nodded. "Under these terms, I accept the match as well," he said.

"Then let everyone take their places!" the king said with excitement. While Jerome went to join the other contestants, Randal and the prince took their places in the center of the arena. Vern felt his chest tighten. As his breathing grew difficult and his mind flooded with complicated thoughts, he placed his hand on the hilt of his sword and waited.

The prince raised his sword and took his stance. Since he did not know what his opponent was capable of, he chose to be cautious. The moment Randal gripped the hilt of his sword, he released it with a muffled whistling sound that echoed throughout the entire arena. He drew an invisible circle to his left with the blade. He raised his sword, loosened his fingers, and let the weapon drop. While the pointed tip faced the ground, he caught the hilt just as he plunged the sword into the earth. While the crowd tried to understand what was happening with bated breath, Randal drew the dagger hanging in the sheath on his leg.

To prevent Randal from putting on any more of a show, the prince lunged forward. In one swift motion, he brought his sword down diagonally from above.

Randal was fast. Compared to the massive body he possessed, he was very, very fast. He escaped by stepping aside from the prince's move, and while doing so, his face bore not the slightest sign of strain.

The prince did not stop. Before the sword even hit the ground, he swung it rapidly in the opposite direction. The moment Randal used the curved part of his dagger to deflect the sword up into the sky, neutralizing it, he took a quick step toward the prince. Drawing power from the foot he first planted on the ground, he kicked the prince in the chest with all his might with his other foot. The prince, whose feet left the ground, was hurled far away as if kicked by a horse. When his back slammed into the ground, although he wanted to scream in pain, only a thin gasp of air came out.

Randal stopped suddenly as he was coming toward the prince's side. When he looked at the ground, he saw the prince's sword at his feet. He bent down and picked the sword up from the ground. After examining the blade for a brief moment, he held it in a reverse grip by the hilt and threw it to the prince. The sword landed right to the prince's right with a clatter.

"Wield your weapon," Randal said, walking toward the prince. The moment the prince placed his hand on the hilt of the sword, Randal pressed his foot down on the tip of the blade.

His eyes were on the necklace trailing from the prince's neck. He firmly caught the chain of the necklace. He pulled the prince toward himself. While bending down himself, he also lifted the prince up. He looked into his eyes. Bringing his own face as close as possible to the prince's, he opened his mouth. He whispered the words to the prince.

Everyone in the arena suddenly fell into a deathly silence, trying to find out what Randal was saying to the prince. Yet the whispers were not heard; Randal's words and the few words that spilled from the prince's mouth as he shook his head side to side were lost there in the nothingness. At that moment, Vern's eyes drifted for a second to the prince's sword. The sword remaining under Randal's foot had bent. With a sense of unease washing over him, Vern tightly gripped his sword resting on its hilt.

The prince realized he couldn't pull his sword free. The moment he let go of the hilt, he punched Randal in the face with all his strength. Randal's head snapped back, but not the slightest mark appeared on his face. This time, Randal slammed his forehead into the prince's nose with all his might.

While blood rushed out of the prince's broken nose, Randal let go of the hand holding the necklace. At that moment, grabbing the prince by his armor, he lifted him into the air. In a sudden motion, he slammed him against the arena wall. While the wooden wall of the arena

scattered pieces of beams around amidst cracking sounds, the prince's knees buckled. With Randal letting go of his collar, he collapsed onto his knees. He raised his head and looked at Randal.

As the blood flowing from his nose filled his mouth, his lips parted.

"... Let... Let honor b..."

Randal kicked the prince in the face with all his might. While the prince's face was completely blood-red, he also began to move randomly, heavily, and erratically, as if he had lost his senses. His hands searched the surroundings to grasp the sword lying on the ground, but the sword was not nearby. His hand could not reach it. Busy looking for his sword, he hadn't seen the second kick coming to his face. While his spiked boots turned crimson with the prince's blood, Randal gripped the prince by the collar once more. He dragged him toward the side of his own sword.

After a momentary hesitation, Vern leapt straight into the arena. Even if it was against the rules, he couldn't allow the prince to take any more of a beating.

Though the prince writhed in pain, the words coming from his mouth were not fully intelligible. He grabbed the hands holding his collar, trying to pry the fingers open. He tried to cut the wrists with his fingernails, but none of it seemed to work. In one motion, Randal lifted the prince and threw him next to his sword that was plunged into the ground.

Vern's cautiously advancing steps quickened. He began to run toward his cousin.

As the prince tried to straighten up from the ground, Randal grabbed him by his hair. Lifting him up slightly, he made him sit on his knees.

"That is enough!" the king shouted. Standing up on his feet, he opened his arms to both sides as he bellowed all his anger into the arena. "We are trying to conduct a duel here. An arena where skills are displayed and men fight for honor! You have stained this event enough with your barbarism! Guards!"

"You should have accepted the deal," Randal said in a whisper.

"Honor... be..."

"I assume it is in the family. You talk too much."

Randal paid no mind to the soldiers rushing toward him. He paid no mind to Vern either, who had freed his sword from its scabbard. Before the prince could finish his sentence, he had covered the prince's mouth with his hand. Although the prince's weak arms grabbed Randal's and tugged at them, it was not enough. With his free hand, Randal caught the necklace and brought it to the side. He bent the prince over. With all his strength, he pushed the prince's head backward.

Accompanied by a sickening sound, while the prince's head fell to the ground along with half of his neck, Randal had already taken the bloody necklace and stood up. While blood spurted from the neck, Vern was by the prince's side. He hadn't made it in time. The scene standing before him did not feel real. He hadn't wanted this to happen. Esmond shouldn't have died. The outcries and shouts of the crowd lost their meaning to him. It was as if Esmond's death had silenced the surroundings completely. With the death of his brother,

nothing had any meaning anymore. Vern collapsed onto his knees with the silence of death. His tears trickled down his cheeks, dripping onto the prince's corpse. He felt a lump form in his throat. While breathing became difficult, he tried to hold back his tears. But it was not working. He rejected reality at that moment. While pain squeezed his heart, wishing that he himself were lying on the ground instead of his cousin, his eyes caught sight of Randal at that very moment.

TO BE CON...